

Maned wolf

Chrysocyon brachyurus



A slender fox- or wolf-like animal, the maned wolf has a different evolutionary lineage from both groups. This little-studied animal is probably an ancient relic that became an isolated species in South America thousands of years ago.

Superficially foxlike

Although not related, a resting maned wolf looks remarkably like a red fox. Large, whitish, triangular, and very mobile ears, and a white throat crescent beneath a prominent black muzzle, give it a distinctly foxlike look. Once it stands up and moves, however, it looks quite different with its high stance and long-striding walk.

The wolf has a long, black crest or rippling mane between the shoulders, and a striking white-tipped tail. Long legs allow it to move easily and see greater distances in the tall, dense grass in which it lives. It has a slightly awkward, undulating gait in open spaces, but in the long grass, it forces its way through with a slower, forward-reaching stride and short leaps.

Lone hunter

The maned wolf is a loner—more like a fox than a wolf—although several may gather where food is abundant. It uses its excellent hearing to locate, stalk, and pounce on prey, killing it by biting on or around the neck or

spine. The wolf prefers mammals, mainly pacas—large rodents—and will eat armadillos, birds, and even fish. However, the maned wolf is remarkable for the large proportion of vegetable matter in its diet. It is fond of the tomatolike wolf apple, the fruit of the lobeira plant, and regularly eats various other fruits and roots. This fruit-rich diet is essential to the animals' health; when captive maned wolves have been given a pure meat diet, they have developed kidney and bladder stones.

Nightly patrols

Maned wolves create tracks through grassland by using regular routes in their nighttime patrols. They defend territories based on these paths, using strongly scented urine as a marker. Females give birth to between two and six pups, which are dependent on their parents for up to a year. The males may help feed the young.

Maned wolves are threatened by habitat loss, and are vulnerable to road traffic. They are sometimes killed by domestic dogs and are susceptible to their diseases, and myths about the medicinal value of their body parts sometimes lead to persecution by humans. Maned wolves require large areas of open ground, and are difficult to keep and even harder to breed in zoos. Their conservation relies on the protection of large areas of suitable habitat.

◀ LONG-LEGGED ROAMER

The maned wolf uses its long legs in an efficient, loping gait, covering long distances each night through its 12–20 sq mile (30–55 sq km) territory.

▷ YOUNG PUP

This pup, almost five weeks old and becoming increasingly inquisitive, will stay with the family group for up to a year.



△ SOCIAL ENCOUNTER

Prominent ears help maned wolves communicate: one lays them flat, in fear or submission, the other raises them, showing dominance.